Gender theory

Hello everyone, and welcome to this fourth episode of the Cottongue Podcast!

[00:00:11] As you already know if you've listened to the previous episodes, the Cottongue Podcast is here to help you learn French. But unlike traditional language podcasts, we don't study grammar here. If you want to study grammar, unfortunately this isn't the right place!

[00:00:37] In this podcast, I talk to you about subjects I find interesting, and I try to explain everything so you can understand as much as possible. And the more you listen to things in French, the more you'll understand. That's why I recommend listening to this podcast several times. And to help you understand, you can also read the podcast transcript on my website, cottongue.com. My website has the transcripts of all the podcasts.

[00:01:22] In the last podcast, I announced today's subject. Do you remember? In the last podcast, I announced that the next subject would be gender theory.

[00:01:38] Have you heard of this before? Have you heard of gender theory? Perhaps this is the first time you've heard of gender theory. In that case, I'm going to explain very simply what it's about.

[00:01:59] Gender theory is the French translation of gender studies. It involves distinguishing between biological sex and gender. On the one hand, there is biological sex, the sex we have at birth, when we're born. The baby is either a boy or a girl. But on the other hand, there is also gender, which is the construction of our sexual identity. In other words, do we feel more like a man or a woman? Sometimes biological sex and gender can be different. For example, if a person was born with a woman's sex but, in their mind, feels more like a man.

[00:03:03] In France, there is controversy surrounding gender theory. In 2014, rumours spread on the internet. A rumour is information that hasn't been verified and that spreads, circulates, that people exchange. So there was a rumour on the internet saying that French schools were teaching gender theory. People who had never heard these words in their lives thought that schools wanted to turn their boys into girls and their girls into boys. Pupils' parents began sending one another text messages to spread this rumour. So the rumour started to grow and become exaggerated. In the text messages, parents said that at nursery school, meaning the school children attend between the ages of three and six, teachers were talking to children about masturbation. The result: in several regions, parents became afraid and kept their children out of school for several days. Obviously, these rumours were completely false. But in 2016, last year, Pope Francis — the pope is the most important person within the Catholic Church — so Pope Francis also took part in the controversy. He stated that French school textbooks, in other words the books used at school, were influencing pupils by teaching them gender theory. And for the pope, gender theory is unnatural because it influences children, pushes them to choose a sexual orientation different from their biological sex.

[00:05:26] But in reality, French school textbooks say almost nothing about gender theory. Some biology books simply explain that, in addition to biological sex, upbringing and society influence the construction of our sexual identity. But no teacher encourages pupils to choose one sexual orientation or another. The pope simply believed the rumours about this subject.

[00:06:07] I think that if there is so much controversy about this subject, it means it's interesting. That's why I decided to talk to you about it today. Perhaps for you, gender theory is something obvious that you know well. Or perhaps, on the contrary, you think this theory is completely false and shouldn't be discussed at school.

[00:06:40] But whatever the case, we're going to look at why this theory is important today and how it can help us better understand our society.

[00:06:53] Are you ready? Then here we go!

[00:07:00] The 1960s and 1970s were the period of sexual liberation in Western countries. Young people, and especially young women, wanted more freedom. They were fed up, they'd had enough of patriarchal society, meaning a society in which men hold all the power. They had obtained the right to vote, and they used it to obtain equality with men in other rights. Women wanted to be equal to men.

[00:07:45] In this context, American feminist intellectuals began to question, to ask themselves questions about, women's place in society. They decided to study inequalities in treatment and regard between men and women. They wanted to understand why women didn't have the same rights as men, why they couldn't practise the same professions as men, for example. Or why there were so few women among researchers and scientists. For centuries, all these things had been considered normal. Nobody opposed them, nobody saw a problem with them. But in the 1960s, many women no longer wanted to accept this state of affairs. They wanted change.

[00:08:54] That's why they created gender studies: to analyse differences between men and women, compare them, measure them, and see whether these differences really exist or whether they were simply invented. For example, for a long time people thought men were better than women at mathematics, that they were more gifted, more talented. People thought men's and women's brains were different, that they didn't work in the same way. Gender studies showed that this theory was false. Men aren't better than women at mathematics.

[00:09:54] The difficulty in understanding gender theory is that it concerns lots of different fields: literature, philosophy, history, psychology, sociology, linguistics, ethics, and so on, and so on. In all these fields, people try to analyse differences between men and women. So it's difficult to bring together all these studies and all their conclusions, their results.

[00:10:35] But be careful: gender theory doesn't say that biological differences between men and women don't exist. Gender theory fully recognises that biological differences do exist. But it also says that many differences aren't biological. They're only the result of our upbringing, of how society regards men and women.

[00:11:13] To help you understand this, I'm going to share a quotation from Simone de Beauvoir. Perhaps you know Simone de Beauvoir. She was a French philosopher who played a major role in the feminist movement in France in the 1970s. Simone de Beauvoir wrote a world-famous book called The Second Sex. And in this book she writes: "One is not born a woman, one becomes one." What does this quotation mean: "One is not born a woman, one becomes one"?

[00:11:52] It means that at birth, when a baby is born, it has a biological sex, but its behaviour is neutral. Whether the baby is a boy or a girl, it wants the same things: it wants to eat, to sleep, to be with its parents. Little boys and little girls have the same biological needs. But then, as the child grows up, it learns to behave differently. If the child is a boy, it will be taught to behave like a boy. And if it's a girl, she will be brought up to become a woman, as Simone de Beauvoir wrote.

[00:12:56] To give you another example, I suggest listening to an extract from a film. This film is called Les garçons et Guillaume, à table! — Boys and Guillaume, Dinner's Ready! It's a French comedy released in 2013. To begin with, I find the title very interesting. In French, we say "à table!" when the meal is ready and we want everyone to come and eat. Generally, parents say "à table!" to call the children who are in their bedrooms. In the title of this film, it's the mother calling her sons to come and eat. But what's strange is that she distinguishes between "the boys" and Guillaume. Yet Guillaume is a boy's name. So why doesn't his mother consider him a boy, like his brothers? That is precisely what this film is about.

[00:14:18] In the extract we're going to listen to, the whole family is gathered for dinner. There is Guillaume's father, his mother, his two brothers and Guillaume himself. Imagine the scene: it's a dinner with the whole family, and the father is talking to his son Guillaume.
Film extract: Les garçons et Guillaume, à table!

[00:14:42] The father: "Right, Guillaume, what sport do you want to do? I've seen your school report. You're hopeless at sport. From now on, I want you to do sport every Saturday. So what sport do you want to do? I don't know, football, athletics, boxing, judo. I don't know. Greco-Roman wrestling!"

[00:15:23] Guillaume: "Piano!"

[00:15:25] Did you understand what's happening in this scene? Guillaume's father has received his school report. It's a document sent by the school to parents with their child's results, their marks. And unfortunately, Guillaume doesn't have good marks in sport. His father tells him he's "hopeless at sport". Being hopeless at something means being very bad, being a "zero". At school, pupils sometimes say, "I'm hopeless at mathematics," or "I'm hopeless at geography." That means they have bad marks in those subjects.

[00:16:19] Because Guillaume has poor results in sport, his father wants him to do sport every weekend, every Saturday. And did you hear which sports he suggests? Football, athletics, boxing, judo and even Greco-Roman wrestling! Greco-Roman wrestling is a combat sport in which you have to bring your opponent down to the ground, to the floor, using only your arms and upper body. Why do you think the father suggests these particular sports? What do all these sports have in common?

[00:17:10] Have you guessed? These sports are considered men's sports. They're very physical, even violent. The father thinks his son Guillaume doesn't behave enough like a boy. That's why he encourages him to do boys' sports, like his brothers do.

[00:17:41] Being sporty is one of the things society expects of boys. People think boys should be sporty and competitive. We see that very clearly in this film extract. In fact, I really recommend watching it. It's a very funny film, but it also teaches us things. Often, comedies are funny and entertaining, but we don't learn anything. They're just entertainment. In this film, Les garçons et Guillaume, à table!, you'll learn interesting things, I'm sure!

[00:18:31] So in this film, we see that a boy learns to become a man through his upbringing. Guillaume doesn't like sport, but his father makes him do it. Guillaume has to conform to the social model of a man. He's obliged to do sport. But for girls, people generally think it isn't very important. If a girl has poor results in sport, if she's hopeless at sport, it doesn't matter. This difference shows us that society doesn't have the same expectations of men and women. That's why men and women behave differently.

[00:19:25] So how do we learn to become a woman or a man?

[00:19:34] When we're children, our parents' upbringing influences us. The most visible example is toys, the objects children have fun with, play with. When you enter a toy shop, you immediately see the section with toys for boys and the section with toys for girls. In the boys' section, everything is blue because people think blue is the colour for boys. And in the girls' section, everything is pink. Do you think boys biologically prefer blue and girls prefer pink? That it's written in their brains that they should like this colour and not that one?

[00:20:31] Of course not! It's simply that boys and girls are taught to like these colours very early, when their parents decorate their bedrooms, for example, or buy them clothes. These decisions by parents and by companies that sell toys influence children's tastes.

[00:20:58] And what toys do parents buy for little boys?

[00:21:03] Their toys are often for waging war or fighting. There are soldiers, superheroes, weapons and so on. So little boys are encouraged to like violent things, fighting.

[00:21:23] For little girls, people tend to buy dolls they can dress or put make-up on. With these dolls, girls are taught that they should pay attention to their appearance, to their clothes.

[00:21:40] You see, from a very early age, children are taught what they're allowed to like or not like and how they should behave. Often, parents aren't even aware of this. They buy these toys simply because they believe that's what their child likes.

[00:22:05] So parents' upbringing influences children and how they construct their gender, their sexual identity. But school also has a major influence.

[00:22:20] People often say boys are better than girls at the hard sciences, such as mathematics or physics. This would explain why engineers are more often men than women. To check this, French researchers carried out a very interesting experiment at a university

near Marseille, in the south of France. The researchers formed two groups of students. There were boys and girls in each group. Then the researchers devised a test. The purpose of this test was to reproduce a complex geometric shape. In other words, the students had to redraw a geometric shape, to copy it. The test was the same for both groups. The difference was that in the first group, the students were told it was a geometry test, and in the second group, they were told it was a drawing test.

[00:23:49] Well, guess what: in group one, which thought it was doing a geometry test, the boys got better marks. And in group two, which thought it was doing a drawing test, the girls got better marks. Even though the principle of the test was exactly the same for both groups! That's surprising, isn't it?

[00:24:19] What does this experiment show us?

[00:24:23] It shows us that stereotypes exist at school and that pupils are victims of these stereotypes. There are no differences between men's and women's brains, only a different perception.

[00:24:42] In school textbooks, great mathematicians or great scientists are often men. Women aren't discussed. So naturally, little girls tend to think these scientific subjects are mainly reserved for boys. For example, there is a scientist very famous in France and Poland called Maria Skłodowska-Curie. She is famous because she received the Nobel Prize in Physics in 1903 with her husband Pierre Curie. And she also received the Nobel Prize in Chemistry in 1911. But in schoolbooks, she's always presented alongside her husband. They always say "Pierre and Marie Curie", as if a woman couldn't succeed without her husband. Yet she received a second Nobel Prize on her own, without her husband. But French textbooks don't discuss that.

[00:26:02] After our parents' upbringing and our studies, it's in the professional world, the world of work, that differences between men and women are created. Once again, people think there are professions reserved for men, such as engineer, firefighter, computer specialist, police officer and so on. And other jobs that are reserved for women: primary-school teacher, nurse, beautician and so on. People say men have the qualities needed for one position and women for another. For a long time, people also thought women couldn't go into politics because they didn't have the necessary qualities. Politicians were all men. So for a woman, it was impossible to have a political career. But the situation has now changed completely. More and more women are going into politics: members of parliament, ministers, even presidents! So we understand that everything people used to think was false. Women have just as many qualities as men for working in politics. It was stereotypes that made us believe the opposite.

[00:27:43] Now, the governments of some countries require parity. Parity means there must be as many women as men. For example, if there are thirty ministers, fifteen ministers must be women and the other fifteen must be men. Thanks to this kind of law, attitudes change. Men begin to regard women differently.

[00:28:15] Yet in businesses, pay inequalities between women and men still exist. Women's salaries are generally lower than men's. In France, this inequality is 19%. That means that for

the same position and the same responsibilities, a woman earns on average 19% less than a man. That’s enormous, and it’s completely unfair! There is no explanation that justifies this difference in pay. Once again, it’s only the result of stereotypes that make people believe men are more qualified, more competent than women. Fortunately, more and more organisations are speaking out against and fighting these inequalities.

[00:29:24] To conclude, we can say that gender theory is very important in helping us become aware of stereotypes linked to sex. Many differences we thought were biological are actually social constructions. Thanks to gender theory, we can show that differences in the treatment and regard of men and women aren’t justified and that we need to fight them, whether at school or at work, wherever. Regardless of our biological sex, we are above all human beings with our own character and our own ambitions. Our success shouldn’t depend on our biological sex.

[00:30:21] That’s it: this is the end of this podcast. I hope you know a little more about gender theory and that this subject has interested you. If you have questions, you can write to me at hugo@innerfrench.com. And as usual, you can find the podcast transcript on my website, innerfrench.com.

[00:30:59] You know that the presidential election in France took place last week. So in the next podcast, I’ll talk to you about the new French president, Mr Emmanuel Macron, his ideas and his programme for France.